WELCOME TO SOC 330: Media and Society

SESSION II, July 6 - August 14, 2026

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Office hours: Zoom, by appointment
SBC: SBS+ (F-DEC)

Course Description

This survey course is designed to introduce students to various intersections of mass media, popular culture, and society. Through a reading of some classic and contemporary works targeting the intersection of media and society, students will explore questions such as: what factors determine the form and content of news media? What exactly is propaganda and how does it function? In what ways has digitization reoriented traditional economic and cultural processes? Has the internet merely reinforced pre-existing social inequalities, or has it provided society with tools to overcome them? Our central objective is to equip ourselves with the necessary perspectives to analyze and think critically about the flow of images, messages,and information in political news, popular culture, and other realms of media(ted) communication.

Expected Learning Outcomes

This class is geared toward advanced students. Students are expected to understand major concepts and methods of inquiry social and behavioral scientists use to explore social, economic and political-cultural phenomena. In addition to building up a conceptual tool kit, students will develop their analytic, methodological, and interpretive skills. Please note that this is a SBS+ (F-DEC) class and students are expected to engage with sociological materials at a deeper level.

Course Materials and Lectures

Readings: Weekly readings will be posted on Brightspace each Monday. These readings will be related to the lectures. The purpose of my lectures is to make them more digestible for you.
Lectures: Each week there will be one or two lectures. Lecture links will be posted on Monday.

All lectures are in the form of video-essays produced by your professor and hosted on youtube.

Assignments

Your grade will be based on a combination of written engagement with sociological theories and two multiple-choice exams. Using AI as a learning support partner is ok, but prompt-engineering the text of your assignments can be detected and will result in referral to the Academic Judiciary.

- **Weekly reflections:** Each week you will submit one 300-word reflection. You should include references to at least one of the readings assigned that week. You may also reference previous weeks if you wish. In this reflection, you will discuss the readings and lectures with reference to the weekly discussion prompt. The discussion prompt might be a question, a news article, a video, or some other form of media. Prompts will be posted on Mondays. The purpose of this assignment is to check your reading comprehension. Weekly reflections are due on brightspace every Monday by 11:59 PM.
- **Final paper:** The course will culminate in a ten-page (double-spaced) final paper in which you will be expected to explore a topic of your choice via the application of one or more of the theoretical approaches covered this semester. The paper will be written in ASA format and will be submitted on Brightspace before 11:59 PM on the last day of class. In this paper you are expected to do the following:
    1. Introduce a social problem of your choice. Provide a brief background of the problem and explain why it is a social problem rather than a personal problem. This problem must be somehow related to one of the module themes.
    2. Summarize the theoretical perspective(s) of your choice. Clearly state the concepts you will be using and explain why they are suitable to analyze the problem.
    3. Apply the theory to imagine a solution to the problem. In an ideal world, what needs to happen socially, politically, and/or culturally to address this problem? What are the first steps?
    4. There is no requirement for the number of citations, but you should use outside citations as necessary, especially when describing your chosen social problem. You must cite at least one of the scholars that we have covered this semester-more is not necessarily better. Your paper must be rooted primarily in course content.

    Your paper should have a clear introduction which poses the social problem and conclusion which summarizes your argument. You will be evaluated primarily on the strength of your argument and the accuracy and competency you demonstrate when applying your chosen theoretical perspective(s).
- **Exams:** The exams will be multiple choice and will be based on lecture content. All exams are cumulative.

Grading Structure

Assignment	Weight
Exam 1 (online, synchronous, 2 hours)	15%
Exam 2 (online, synchronous, 2 hours)	15%
Weekly reflections	25%
Final paper	45%

Grade Range	Outcome
93-100	A
90-92	A-
87-89	B+
83-86	B
80-82	B-
77-79	C+
73-76	C
70-72	C-
67-69	D+
63-66	D
< 63	F

Course Schedule and Readings

Week	Topic	Watch / Read	Deadlines (11:59 PM on Brightspace)
1	The Social Construction of News	**Watch:** Why the News isn't 'Objective' **Read:** Schudson (Ch. 6, 7, 10); McLuhan (Ch. 1)	None! Take this week to get ahead on your reading.
2	Media and Propaganda	**Watch:** Jacques Ellul; C. Wright Mills **Read:** Ellul (Preface, Ch. 2); Mills (Ch. 1, 13)	Weekly Reflection 1: Due Monday, July 13
3	Digitization and Economy	**Watch:** Chris Anderson lecture **Read:** Anderson (The Long Tail); Zuboff (Ch. 1-3)	Weekly Reflection 2: Due Monday, July 20 Exam 1: Friday, July 24 (Online, 2-hour limit)
4	Cultural Critiques of Media	**Watch:** Neil Postman; Critical Theory (Adorno & Horkheimer) **Read:** Adorno & Horkheimer; Postman (Ch. 1-3)	Weekly Reflection 3: Due Monday, July 27 Final Paper Proposal: Due Friday, July 31
5	Politics and Social Media	**Watch:** Why Everyone Seems More Extreme Online **Read:** Shirky (Ch. 3, 4, 6); Bail (Ch. 1-3); DiMaggio et al.	Weekly Reflection 4: Due Monday, August 3

Week	Topic	Watch / Read	Deadlines (11:59 PM on Brightspace)
6	Intro to Cybernetics	**Watch:** Actor-Network Theory; Cyborg Manifesto **Read:** Latour (pp. 63-87); Haraway	Weekly Reflection 5: Due Monday, August 10 Exam 2: Friday, August 14 Final Paper: Due Friday, August 14

Course Policies

Late policy: Let your instructor know immediately if you will submit work late, including the weekly reflections and final paper. Each student is permitted to turn in up to two assignments late at no penalty. After this, you will receive a 25% point deduction per day. Assignments submitted more than 48 hours late will not be accepted. Considerations will be made for students with accessibility challenges.
Exam policy: All missed exams must promptly be taken with instructor approval during office hours within two weeks. Please contact the instructor before the day of the exam in the event that you will not be able to take it on time. In the event that you must miss an exam, you must receive pre-approval from the instructor or submit proof of extenuating circumstances. Whenever possible, you should let the instructor know in advance if you will miss an exam.

Stony Brook University Policies

- **Student Accessibility Support Center:** If you have a physical, psychological, medical, or learning disability that may impact your course work, please contact the Student Accessibility Support Center, Stony Brook Union Suite 107, (631) 632-6748, or at sasc@stonybrook.edu. They will determine with you what accommodations are necessary and appropriate. All information and documentation is confidential.
- **Academic Integrity Statement:** Each student must pursue his or her academic goals honestly and be personally accountable for all submitted work. Representing another person's work as your own is always wrong. Faculty is required to report any suspected instances of academic dishonesty to the Academic Judiciary. Faculty in the Health Sciences Center (School of Health Technology & Management, Nursing, Social Welfare, Dental Medicine) and School of Medicine are required to follow their school-specific procedures.
- **Critical Incident Management:** Stony Brook University expects students to respect the rights, privileges, and property of other people. Faculty are required to report to the Office of University

Community Standards any disruptive behavior that interrupts their ability to teach, compromises the safety of the learning environment, or inhibits students' ability to learn. Faculty in the HSC Schools and the School of Medicine are required to follow their school specific procedures. Further information about most academic matters can be found in the Undergraduate Bulletin, the Undergraduate Class Schedule, and the Faculty Employee Handbook.